



LUCKY NUMBER 3

In the Olympic year it might take more than just the Olympic **standard** to join Neeraj and Jena in Paris.

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Finishing sixth in the final of the World Championships might be the kind of debut most athletes might only dream about. However, despite throwing his season's second best of 84.14m (the best being 84.33m), his performance at Worlds 2023 in Budapest left DP Manu unsatisfied.

During the Asian Games in Hangzhou, the 23-year-old from Karnataka was not part of the

« The qualification of three javelin throwers for the Olympics would be a landmark moment in Indian athletics »

Two to tango: Two Indians have directly qualified for the Paris Games already — Neeraj Chopra did so with his first throw at the World Championships while Kishore Jena followed suit at the Asian Games with a silver medal. PTI

Indian contingent. Therefore, from his base at the Army Sports Institute in Pune, he watched history unfold with Olympic and World champion Neeraj Chopra securing yet another gold medal and Kishore Kumar Jena, who had placed fifth at the Worlds, clinching a silver. This marked India's first ever 1-2 podium finish in javelin at the Asian Games.

Manu says it could have well been a 1-2-3 finish. "I know if I had competed I would also have made the podium. I was throwing well and in really good form. Plus Neeraj *bhaiyya* was there and when other Indians throw with him, our level also goes up," he says. Indeed the bronze medal at Hangzhou was won by Japan's Genki Dean Thomas, with a throw of 82.44m — a mark Manu had crossed thrice prior to the Asian Games.

Manu couldn't travel to the Asian Games because of the nature of the qualification system, which mandated that countries send only two representatives for each event. In